

Myths, legends and folklore from Switzerland

#MythicalMondays

reflectiveponderer

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To begin my #MythicalMondays series, I decided on starting off with Switzerland. The idea for this post had come to me for the first time last year, during the Fasnacht, as I started asking my friends what the Basilisk was. So, I read up on some of the myths and legends, and here are a few of them from the beautiful country of Switzerland. If you know of any more, do let me know. I will be focusing on a different country each month. So, you are most welcome to get in touch with me if you would like to contribute towards the blog. So, let's get into exploring some myths, legends and stories from Switzerland –

1. The Basilisk – If you happen to visit Basel, you will see mentions of 'Basilisk' around the city. You will also notice several fountains and statues of a strange creature, that partially resembles a dragon or a snake. On asking around, I got introduced to the story behind it. The Basilisk is a mythical creature, that dates back to as far as the 1400's. It is said to have been extremely poisonous and could kill people in one glance alone. The Greek word 'Basileus' means King, and the creature could have been referred to, as the King of snakes. Apparently, it was born when a cockerel laid an egg that was incubated by a snake. As bizarre as this sounds, it has been mentioned in various stories, plays and even in *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*. The Basilisk was a powerful creature, that is depicted as a small dragon, with the tail of a snake and the head of a cockerel. It would not glide like a snake but walk upright, and could even kill the grass if it moved across it. The only way to kill it was to show it its own reflection.



A Basilisk fountain along the Rhine in Basel. Picture source: Souvik Ghosh

The Basilisk has been an important symbol of Basel for at least 500 years, and is seen holding the coat of arms, even today. A monument commemorating the great destruction of the city in the 1356 earthquake, has an epitaph which says:

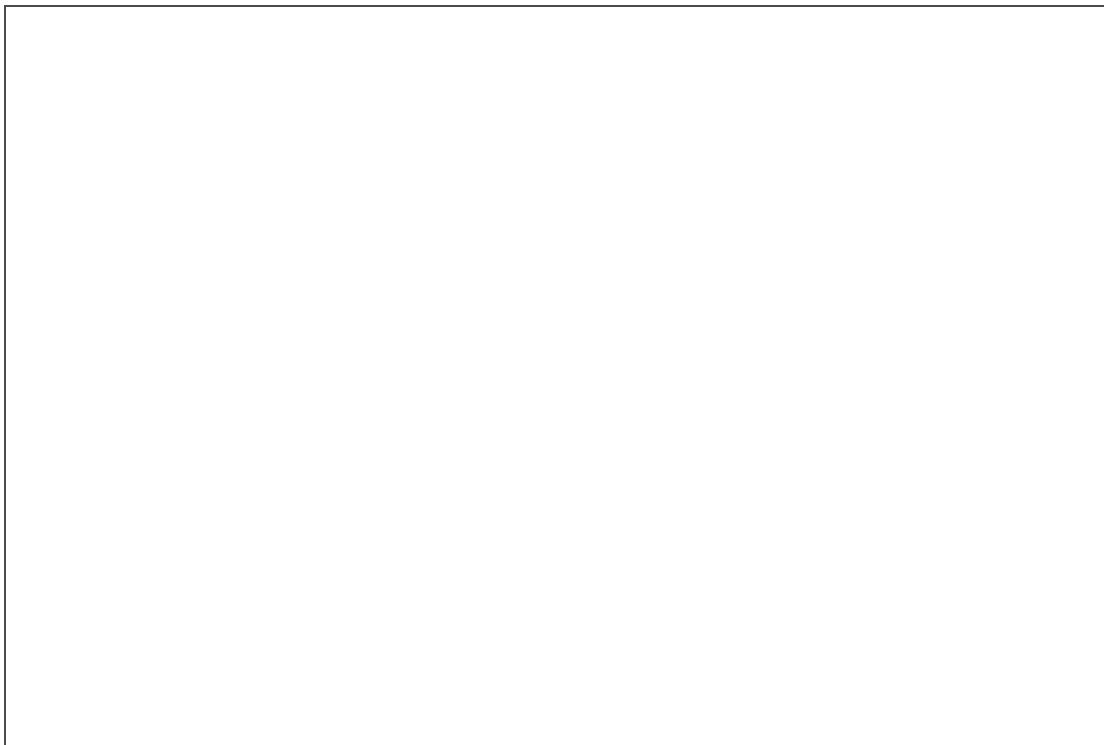
“Basilisk, you poisonous worm and fable, now you shall hold the shield of the dignified city of Basel”.

2. William Tell – A lot of you may be familiar with the legend of William Tell, who was forced to shoot an arrow across an apple off his son’s head. This is said to have happened in Uri, located in Central Switzerland. [Legend](#) has it that a tyrant bailiff called Gessler demanded that people greeted his hat on a rod, when they saw it in the streets. When William Tell refused, he was taken captive, and was forced to shoot the apple on his son’s head. He had a second arrow ready for the tyrant, in case he would have harmed his son, but luckily, his aim was perfect. Later on, he was responsible for killing Gessler. Historians have argued over the existence of Tell and this story, but William Tell became an important part of the Swiss culture. He became a symbol of liberty, and was looked up to, during times of war and revolution. The Museum of William Tell is located in Bürglen (Uri, Central Switzerland), where Tell lived according to the legend. You can also attend an open-air theatre performance based on this story at Interlaken.

3. Heidi – Heidi is a story about a young girl in the Swiss Alps, written in 1880 by Johanna Spyri. Several movies and cartoons have been made based on the novel, and the book as well as the adaptations have been extremely popular throughout the world.

4.The witch of Belalp – Witch hunting was common in Europe in the Middle Ages. But, there is one story that is remembered even today. A certain witch in the Belalp region was accused of being responsible for her husband's death, and was burned at stake. Now, this story is commemorated by a week long skiing event (in January) in Belalp, in which people dress up as witches, wear masks, and participate in the 12 km long 'Witches' Descent'. Meanwhile, cries of „D'Häx isch los!“ can be heard, which translates to “The Witch is loose!” However, I came across an elaborate story in an article written by [Christina Pfeiffer at traveltherenext.com](http://traveltherenext.com),

“Legend has it that a witch who was married to a pious man fell in love with a sorcerer. Whenever the lovers wanted to meet, they turned themselves into black ravens. One day the witch was at the top of the Aletsch glacier boiling soup in a cauldron, she discovered that she had run out of garlic and raced down the glacier to her herb garden for some fresh garlic. On her way, she spotted her pious husband perched high up on a branch of a cherry tree picking fruit. The witch turned herself into a black raven and flew up to greet him. At that very moment, the pious husband had decided to say his afternoon prayers and as he turned his face towards the sky, the raven inadvertently deposited bird droppings into his eye. Blinded, he fell off the tree and died instantly. The village authorities accused the witch of using her cauldron to cast an evil spell on her husband and she was burned at the stake. Centuries later, the Belalp ski club formed the Belalp Hexe in honour of this poor misunderstood witch. The finishing line of the race is believed to be at the very spot where the pious husband dropped dead in the cherry tree.”



All set for the Belalps 'Witches' Descent' skiing event! Picture source: Acecabana.com

Picture source: Acecabana

5.The dragons of Mt.Pilatus– Mount Pilatus in the Lucerne region is a hotspot for tourists. However, interesting stories and legends stem from there. For instance, one legend says that dragons with healing powers lived in the crevices of the mountain. Another story also details how a young cooper was stuck on Mount Pilatus, but stayed safe in a dragon's cave through the winter. A different legend also stems from the region, according to which, the body of Pontius Pilate was sunk in the Lake Oberalp on Mount Pilatus, after trying to sink the body in other rivers. The ghost of Pilate appeared to cause thunderstorms in the area. People believed that it rose every year

on Good Friday, 'to wash the blood of Christ from its hands'. He is said to have ultimately found peace in Pilatus.

6.The Dwarfs of the Alps – I came across some stories of 'The Dwarfs, or Earth-men' of Switzerland, who are said to have been lively, helpful and very kind. They were mainly involved in rearing chamois, a type of cattle whose milk was used to make a tasty and special kind of cheese. This cheese had the property of re-growing, after being cut. But ofcourse, the owner had to make sure that he did not finish off the entire piece of cheese, and left a little portion at the end to let it sprout. Several interesting stories about these dwarfs can be found on [this website](#).

7.Teufelsbrücke or Devil's Bridge– This is a bridge located in Central Switzerland, in the [Schöllenen Gorge](#). It was extremely difficult to construct it, and a myth says that owing to the level of difficulty, the Devil himself agreed to carry out the task. But ofcourse, he had a condition. He wanted to take the soul of the first to cross the bridge. When the time came, the locals chased a goat over it. Tricked by the villagers, the Devil was so angry that he wanted to smash the bridge and went ahead to get a huge stone- which is referred to, as the 'Devil's Stone'. On his way, he saw a woman carrying a cross, and got scared by it. In that moment of fear, he dropped the stone and fled. The stone can be seen near [Göschenen](#).

8.Vogel Gryff Basel- I am ending this blog with another legend and tradition observed in Basel. On one particular afternoon in January, the city of Basel observes a tradition in which three symbolic figures of the societies of KleinBasel – Wilder Mann (the savage man), Leu (the lion) and Vogel Gryff (the griffin) meet at Mittlere Brücke and dance, while facing KleinBasel. Basel is divided into two parts: Gross, meaning 'large' and Klein, meaning 'small'. In earlier times, the different societies served political purposes, but in 1841, they moved to the same building and started having a joint celebration every year. Switzerland Tourism offers more information on their [website](#).